particularly feared the backlash they would face if they targeted a company that had made substantial investments for the welfare of the marginalized.

Ratan set much store by the need to provide health infrastructure, especially in the most underdeveloped areas, such as in upper Assam, which were very poor and lacked even basic medical facilities. To this end, Tata Tea advanced the construction of a new hospital in Chabua in upper Assam, which it completed in 1994. The project cost Rs 7 crore and brought immense relief to the local population.

The group also took up a new initiative called Lifeline Express into Assam in 1995, which extended 'critically needed medical assistance to people from the weaker sections' of society. It also re-energized its 'Outreach Medical Programme' under which fully equipped ambulances with doctors travelled to remote rural areas, recalled Krishna Kumar. It became a very popular programme. Under it, nearly 3,000 patients were examined in the months of August–September 1997. In addition, the North Bank Outreach Programme provided medical assistance to villagers five days a week in remote areas where 'even Government medical aid [was] not available'.

Violence, however, continued to rock the state. The state government had taken some steps ostensibly to improve the security in the tea estates. The Assam Tea Plantation Security Force (ATPSF) was set up in 1993 and the expenses of maintaining it were borne by the tea industry. However, it was no match for the militants. Lamenting the situation, V.K. Goenka, vice president of the Indian Tea Association (ITA), a premier tea body, said, 'We are not happy with the security provided to the tea gardens in Assam. We will request the state government to strengthen it.'

Faced with the security situation, many companies moved their tea business out of Assam. Tata Tea, on the other hand, decided to stay and ride out the crisis, embracing Ratan's approach of refusing to pay the militants but undertaking welfare schemes. In a letter to the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) president, Ratan later clarified, 'The Company, however [at the time] kept this option [of leaving] aside.'

But the Tata Group continued to be under pressure from the militants. On 17 October 1995, Digvijay Singh and Arindam Dutta, manager and assistant manager respectively of Nonoi Tea Estate in the Nagaon district, were kidnapped. Although they were rescued in forty-eight hours, the writing on the wall was clear.